

US Diplomatic Mission Status Data — Codebook

Version 0.2

Brenton Kenkel

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1 Overview

This dataset records the status of U.S. diplomatic missions abroad, matched to standard state system membership data. It covers all countries recognized by the Correlates of War (COW) and Gleditsch-Ward (GW) state system datasets, from the earliest date of system membership through the end of the most recent available data.

The primary source is the Office of the Historian, U.S. Department of State, *A Guide to the United States' History of Recognition, Diplomatic, and Consular Relations, by Country, since 1776*, available in machine-readable XML at <https://github.com/HistoryAtState/rdcr>. Ambiguities in the primary source are resolved by consulting *Principal Officers & Chiefs of Mission* (<https://github.com/HistoryAtState/pocom>).

The underlying transition events were hand-coded from these sources, then validated against the XML records using a combination of automated extraction and manual reconciliation. For details on the extraction and validation pipeline, see the project repository at https://github.com/brentonk/us_diplomatic_missions.

The dataset is maintained by Brenton Kenkel, Vanderbilt University (brenton.kenkel@gmail.com). If you have any questions or corrections, email me directly, or file an issue on GitHub at https://github.com/brentonk/us_diplomatic_missions/issues.

2 Datasets

The data is provided in three temporal resolutions, each matched to three state system definitions, for a total of nine CSV files. All filenames include the version number (currently v0.2).

2.1 State system definitions

- **COW** (Correlates of War): The standard COW state system membership list (2024 version). Files use the suffix `_cow`.
- **GW** (Gleditsch-Ward): The Gleditsch-Ward state system membership list, excluding microstates. Files use the suffix `_gw`.

- **GWM** (Gleditsch-Ward with microstates): The Gleditsch-Ward list supplemented with micro and island states. Files use the suffix `_gwm`. GW and GWM share the same coding system (abbreviations, numeric codes, and country names); they differ only in which states are included.

2.2 Distributed files

2.2.1 Range datasets (one row per country–date range)

- `mission_status_range_cow_v0.2.csv`
- `mission_status_range_gw_v0.2.csv`
- `mission_status_range_gwm_v0.2.csv`

2.2.2 Monthly datasets (one row per country-code–month)

- `mission_status_monthly_cow_v0.2.csv`
- `mission_status_monthly_gw_v0.2.csv`
- `mission_status_monthly_gwm_v0.2.csv`

2.2.3 Yearly datasets (one row per country-code–year)

- `mission_status_yearly_cow_v0.2.csv`
- `mission_status_yearly_gw_v0.2.csv`
- `mission_status_yearly_gwm_v0.2.csv`

3 Diplomatic status categories

Each observation records the highest level of U.S. diplomatic representation in the recipient country. The categories, ordered from greatest to least, are:

1. **Embassy**: Permanent diplomatic mission headed by an ambassador.
2. **Ambassador Nonresident**: Nonresident ambassadorial relations — ambassadors accredited to the country but not resident there.
3. **Legation**: Permanent diplomatic mission of lower status than an embassy, typically headed by an Envoy Extraordinary and Minister Plenipotentiary. Largely phased out after World War II.
4. **Envoy Nonresident**: Nonresident envoy relations — envoys or ministers accredited to the country but not resident there.
5. **Consulate**: Consular office in the capital city. Only coded if located in the capital.
6. **Consul Nonresident**: Nonresident consular relations.
7. **Liaison**: Liaison office or informal diplomatic presence (e.g., “Office of the U.S. Representative,” “Diplomatic Agent”).
8. **Interests**: Interests section — diplomats of one state working under the flag of a second on the territory of a third, used to maintain communication when formal relations are broken.
9. **None**: No formal diplomatic representation.

3.1 Date coding rules

- When the records specify the date an embassy, legation, or consulate general opened, that date is used.
- If no specific opening date for the mission is provided, the date of presentation of credentials by the first chief of mission is used.
- For elevations of existing relations (e.g., legation to embassy), the date of formal elevation is used, even if there is a lag before the new ambassador presents credentials.
- For newly established relations, the date of credential presentation by the first envoy/ambassador is used.
- When State Department records are ambiguous about exact dates, as much information as possible is recorded: dates with a known year but unknown month or day are mapped to January 1 or the first of the month, respectively.

3.2 Coding conventions

- Missions (e.g., to France and Prussia in the 1700s) are coded as legations.
- “Office of the U.S. Representative” (e.g., Marshall Islands) and “Diplomatic Agent” (e.g., Morocco) are coded as liaison offices.
- Nonresident charges d’affaires and nonresident ministers are coded at the level of the mission they represent: Envoy Nonresident if serving at the envoy level, Ambassador Nonresident if serving at the ambassadorial level.
- Consulates are only coded if located in the capital.
- Governments in exile during WWII: “embassy near the government” is treated as an open embassy.

4 Column definitions

4.1 Range datasets

The unit of observation is the **country–date range**. Each row represents a period during which a country’s diplomatic status was constant.

Column	Description
<code>country_abbrev_cow / country_abbrev_gw</code>	Country abbreviation in the state system (e.g., AFG , HAI).
<code>country_code_cow / country_code_gw</code>	Numeric country code in the state system (e.g., 700, 41).
<code>country_name_cow / country_name_gw</code>	Country name in the state system (e.g., Afghanistan , Haiti).
<code>country_name_usdos</code>	Country name in U.S. Department of State records. Empty if no match exists. Rows are split when the USDOS name mapping changes over time.
<code>date_start</code>	Start date of the range (YYYY-MM-DD).

Column	Description
<code>date_end</code>	End date of the range (YYYY-MM-DD), inclusive.
<code>us_mission_status</code>	Diplomatic status during this range. One of the nine status strings listed in Section 3.

For each country, the date ranges form a proper partition of the state system membership dates: no gaps, no overlaps, and complete coverage. Status carries forward across gaps in system membership (e.g., a country that exits and re-enters the system retains its most recent status at re-entry, if a transition occurred during the gap).

GW and GWM datasets use the `_gw` column suffix and share the same coding system. They differ only in which states are included.

4.2 Monthly datasets

The unit of observation is **country-code-month**. Aggregation is over all days in the month for a given state system code.

Column	Description
<code>country_abbrev_cow /</code> <code>country_abbrev_gw</code>	Country abbreviation.
<code>country_code_cow /</code> <code>country_code_gw</code>	Numeric country code.
<code>country_name_cow /</code> <code>country_name_gw</code>	Country name.
<code>country_name_usdos</code>	USDOS name(s). If the name changes within the month, all applicable names are concatenated with /. Empty if no match.
<code>month</code>	Month in YYYY-MM format.
<code>us_mission_min</code>	Least diplomatic status observed on any day in the month.
<code>us_mission_max</code>	Greatest diplomatic status observed on any day in the month.
<code>us_mission_median</code>	Median diplomatic status across all days in the month.
<code>us_mission_mode</code>	Most frequent diplomatic status across all days in the month.
<code>us_mission_start</code>	Diplomatic status on the first observed day of the month.
<code>us_mission_end</code>	Diplomatic status on the last observed day of the month.

Status comparisons use the ordering in Section 3 (Embassy is the greatest, None is the least). Ties in the median or mode are broken in favor of the greater status.

The first and last “observed day” of the month in `us_mission_start` and `us_mission_end` account for the fact that the country may enter or leave the state system mid-month.

4.3 Yearly datasets

The unit of observation is **country-code–year**. Structure is identical to the monthly datasets, with `year` (YYYY format) replacing `month`.

5 Generating daily data

Daily-level datasets are not distributed due to their size (approximately 6–7 million rows per state system definition). They can be generated from the range datasets by expanding each date range into individual rows.

5.1 Daily dataset columns

Column	Description
<code>country_abbrev_cow</code> / <code>country_abbrev_gw</code>	Country abbreviation.
<code>country_code_cow</code> / <code>country_code_gw</code>	Numeric country code.
<code>country_name_cow</code> / <code>country_name_gw</code>	Country name.
<code>country_name_usdos</code>	USDOS name. Empty if no match.
<code>date</code>	Date in YYYY-MM-DD format.
<code>us_mission_status</code>	Diplomatic status on that date.

5.2 Sample code

The samples below generate daily COW data. For Gleditsch-Ward, replace `_cow` with `_gw` or `_gwm` in the file name.

Daily data files are also available on request from the maintainer.

5.2.1 R (tidyverse)

```
library(tidyverse)

range_df <- read_csv("mission_status_range_cow_v0.2.csv")

daily_df <- range_df |>
  mutate(date = map2(date_start, date_end, ~ seq(.x, .y, by = "day"))) |>
  unnest(date) |>
  select(-date_start, -date_end)
```

5.2.2 Python (pandas)

```
import pandas as pd

range_df = pd.read_csv("mission_status_range_cow_v0.2.csv",
                       parse_dates=["date_start", "date_end"])

daily_rows = []
for _, row in range_df.iterrows():
    dates = pd.date_range(row["date_start"], row["date_end"], freq="D")
    for d in dates:
        daily_rows.append(**row.drop(["date_start", "date_end"]), "date": d)

daily_df = pd.DataFrame(daily_rows)
```

5.2.3 Python (polars)

```
import polars as pl

range_df = pl.read_csv("mission_status_range_cow_v0.2.csv",
                       try_parse_dates=True)

daily_df = (
    range_df
    .with_columns(date=pl.date_ranges("date_start", "date_end"))
    .explode("date", empty_as_null=False)
    .drop("date_start", "date_end")
)
```

5.2.4 Stata

```
import delimited "mission_status_range_cow_v0.2.csv", clear
gen date_start_d = date(date_start, "YMD")
gen date_end_d = date(date_end, "YMD")
gen n_days = date_end_d - date_start_d + 1
expand n_days
bysort country_code_cow date_start (date_start): gen date = date_start_d + _n - 1
format date %td
drop date_start* date_end* n_days
```

6 State system definitions

The data is matched to two widely used state system membership datasets, each defining which political entities count as sovereign states and when.

6.1 Correlates of War (COW)

The Correlates of War project’s state system membership list (2024 version). COW defines system membership beginning in 1816, with most entries starting in the 19th or 20th century. Each state is identified by a three-letter abbreviation (e.g., AFG) and a numeric code (e.g., 700).

Source: Correlates of War Project, “State System Membership List, v2024,” <https://correlatesofwar.org/data-sets/state-system-membership/>.

6.2 Gleditsch-Ward (GW)

The Gleditsch-Ward state system membership list, as revised and extended by Gleditsch and Ward (1999). GW uses similar conventions to COW but differs in its criteria for statehood, resulting in different membership dates and country lists. Each state is identified by a two- to five-letter abbreviation and a numeric code.

Source: Kristian Skrede Gleditsch and Michael D. Ward, “Interstate System Membership: A Revised List of the Independent States since 1816,” *International Interactions* 25, no. 4 (1999): 393–413.

6.3 Gleditsch-Ward with microstates (GWM)

The GW list supplemented with micro and island states that are not included in the standard GW data. Uses the same coding system as GW.

6.4 USDOS name mapping

State system codes are mapped to U.S. Department of State country names using a hand-maintained mapping file. Some codes have date-bounded entries where the USDOS name changes over time (e.g., COW code YUG maps to “Kingdom of Serbia/Yugoslavia” before 1992 and “Serbia” after). When the USDOS name changes within a state system membership interval, the range data is split at the boundary so that each row has a unique `country_name_usdos` value.

7 Special cases

7.1 China and Taiwan

Under the One-China Policy, the State Department does not treat Taiwan as a separate entity from mainland China. Historical U.S. diplomatic relations with Taiwan are recorded within the State Department’s China page. In this dataset, they are coded separately under a distinct USDOS name (“Taiwan”) to avoid confusion when merging with state system membership data, as both COW and Gleditsch-Ward list Taiwan as a separate member.

Key coding decisions:

- The establishment of the People’s Republic of China (1949-10-01) is coded as the date of the break in relations with China (status changes to None).
- Taiwan’s embassy is coded as beginning on 1949-12-08, its date of system entry in both the COW and Gleditsch-Ward datasets, even though the U.S. embassy in Taipei did not physically open until 1949-12-19. This is because the U.S. embassy in mainland China had been moved repeatedly throughout 1949 to remain near the Nationalist government, and using the system entry date ensures consistency with the treatment of European governments in exile during WWII.
- The break in relations with Taiwan is coded as 1979-01-01 (U.S. recognition of the PRC).

8 Mapping gaps

The following state system member codes have no corresponding entry in the USDOS diplomatic history. In the data, these entities have an empty `country_name_usdos` value and `us_mission_status` is set to “None” for all dates.

8.1 COW

Code	Number	Name	Membership
HAN	240	Hanover	1837–1866
SAX	269	Saxony	1816–1867
HSE	273	Hesse Electoral	1816–1866
MOD	332	Modena	1842–1860
PMA	335	Parma	1851–1860
TUS	337	Tuscany	1816–1860
PRK	731	North Korea	1948–2024
BHU	760	Bhutan	1971–2024

8.2 GW

Code	Number	Name	Membership
HAN	240	Hanover	1816–1871
SAX	269	Saxony	1816–1871
HSE	273	Hesse-Kassel (Electoral)	1816–1871
MOD	332	Modena	1816–1861
PMA	335	Parma	1816–1861
TUS	337	Tuscany	1816–1861
TRA	563	Transvaal	1852–1910
TBT	711	Tibet	1913–1950
PRK	731	Korea, People’s Republic of	1948–2020
BHU	760	Bhutan	1949–2020

Code	Number	Name	Membership
VNM	815	Vietnam (Annam/Cochin China/Tonkin)	1816–1893

8.3 GWM

Code	Number	Name	Membership
HAN	240	Hanover	1816–1871
SAX	269	Saxony	1816–1871
HSE	273	Hesse-Kassel (Electoral)	1816–1871
MOD	332	Modena	1816–1861
PMA	335	Parma	1816–1861
TUS	337	Tuscany	1816–1861
ABK	396	Abkhazia	2008–2020
SOT	397	South Ossetia	2008–2020
TRA	563	Transvaal	1852–1910
TBT	711	Tibet	1913–1950
PRK	731	Korea, People’s Republic of	1948–2020
BHU	760	Bhutan	1949–2020
VNM	815	Vietnam (Annam/Cochin China/Tonkin)	1816–1893

The following entities appear in the USDOS diplomatic records but do not correspond to any code in the given state system. They are included in the hand-coded transitions data but excluded from the corresponding panel datasets.

COW: Brunswick and Lüneburg, Central American Federation, Hanseatic Republics, Hawaii, Holy See, Nassau, Orange Free State, Republic of Genoa, Texas.

GW / GWM: Brunswick and Lüneburg, Hanseatic Republics, Hawaii, Holy See, Nassau, Republic of Genoa, Texas.

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